

between 12:00 p.m. and on or before 4 p.m. local time, when the sun is at its fiercest. A study published by the National Library of Medicine predicts Monterrey, Boston, Philadelphia, Kansas City, New York and Miami to be at the highest risk of heat.

Subsequently, the first four cities on that list have been given only a combined four matches that kick off on or before 4 p.m.

The heavy lifting during the afternoon will be done by arenas that have the liberty of closing the roof and regulating their own temperature.

The AT&T Stadium and NRG Stadium in Dallas and Houston, along with the Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta, will account for 17 afternoon kick-offs, while the SoFi Stadium in Los Angeles has a translucent, cable-net canopy that will aid five more. But there are only so many risk management steps that can be taken.

Meanwhile, the other two cities share five midday games between them, with MetLife Stadium in New Jersey, located eight kilometres from New York, set to host the final on July 17, which kicks off at 3:00 p.m.

According to the National Centers for Environmental Information, since 2016, in June and July, the average maximum temperature in Miami and New Jersey is 33.07°C and 29.16°C, respectively. For context, when the Wet Bulb Globe Temperature (a comprehensive heat stress index) exceeds 28°C, the average human body ceases to properly cool itself through sweating.

This, in turn, increases the probability of Exertional Heat Illness (EIH), a spectrum of health issues that includes cramps, dizziness and even heat stroke in extreme cases.

Response measures

Although a professional player is expected to have better endurance than the average human, as a precautionary measure, FIFA has



announced that every match at the World Cup will have three-minute hydration breaks in either half.

The intervals have been deemed a necessity and will be imposed 22 minutes into each period, irrespective of where the games are played or in what conditions, unlike FIFA's previous rule, where matches were paused only when the WBGT reached 32°C. While this comes as a welcome move, U.S. men's national team coach Mauricio Pochettino believes that the break should not be mandatory, especially in stadiums where the effect of heat can be controlled.

"To be honest, I don't like it because I think you cut the rhythm of the game. I understand that when you play in open stadiums, maybe yes, we need to care about the health of the players. But in this type of stadium, when it's 21, 22, 23 degrees [Celsius], I think it's the perfect time and weather to play.

But that's the new rule that we need to accept," he said, following his side's 2-5 friendly loss against

Breakpoint: As a precautionary measure, FIFA has announced that every match at the World Cup will have three-minute hydration breaks in either half. GETTY IMAGES

Belgium in Atlanta in March.

Managers may have contrasting opinions on the matter, but another benefactor of the breaks will be broadcasters, who have been given the green light by FIFA to cut to commercials during this period. However, according to reports, FIFA has instructed that ads should not begin within 20 seconds of the referee blowing his whistle, and must end at least 30 seconds ahead of the restart.

It remains to be seen whether the measures taken will affect performances on the pitch. Unlike its predecessor Qatar, by choosing not to postpone the 'greatest show on earth' from its traditional summer slot to winter, have the host nations undertaken a task that is too hot to handle?